

Next Generation ACO Model Data Methodology

Overview

The Next Generation Accountable Care Organization (NGACO) Model dataset provides summary-level information on participating organizations and the Medicare beneficiaries aligned to them. The dataset includes high-level information such as aligned beneficiary counts, benchmark and expenditure amounts, shared savings or shared losses, quality performance, and broad Medicare spending categories.

The [NGACO Model](#) was an initiative for ACOs experienced in coordinating care for populations of patients. The Model tested whether strong financial incentives for ACOs—together with tools to support better patient engagement and care management—could improve health outcomes and lower expenditures for Original Medicare Fee-For-Service (FFS) beneficiaries.

Data content, structure, and privacy protections

The dataset includes summarized information on:

- The number of beneficiaries aligned to each ACO
- Baseline and benchmark expenditure amounts
- Total Medicare spending during the performance year
- Shared savings or shared losses
- Quality performance results
- High-level breakdowns of Medicare spending by service category
- Additional information used in annual financial reconciliation processes

All data is provided in summary form, with no individual level records included. The data files do not contain any Personally Identifiable Information (PII) or Protected Health Information (PHI), and sensitive identifiers are not disclosed to ensure beneficiary confidentiality.

Each dataset release includes a data dictionary describing variable names and file structure.

For additional definitions, see the benchmark methodology resources in the Additional Information section of the [NGACO model page](#).

Data source and model context

The dataset is drawn from administrative information used to manage and evaluate the NGACO Model. Participating organizations were groups of health care providers working together to coordinate care for aligned Medicare beneficiaries.

For each performance year, a prospective financial benchmark was established representing expected Medicare spending for each organization's aligned population. Actual expenditures were compared to the benchmark to determine shared savings or shared losses, and quality performance contributed to final financial results.

The dataset summarizes these core elements—beneficiary alignment, benchmark amounts, expenditures, risk scores, and quality performance—based on information used in annual financial reconciliation.

Dataset timeline

Performance Years 1–6

This methodology covers the datasets for Performance Years 1 through 6 (PY1–PY6). Each performance-year dataset reflects the organizations active during that year and the aligned beneficiaries attributed to them.

Performance Year 1 (PY1): 2016

The PY1 data file includes 18 ACOs active during 2016.

Performance Year 2 (PY2): 2017

The PY2 data file includes 44 ACOs active during 2017.

Performance Year 3 (PY3): 2018

The PY3 data file includes 50 ACOs active during 2018.

Performance Year 4 (PY4): 2019

The PY4 data file includes 41 ACOs active during 2019.

Performance Year 5 (PY5): 2020

The PY5 data file includes 37 ACOs active during 2020. (This file also contains a COVID-19 amendment field.)

Performance Year 6 (PY6): 2021

The PY6 data file includes 35 ACOs active during 2021, the final year of the model.

Note: Starting in PY4–PY6, additional fields appear in the data files. Refer to the corresponding data dictionaries for details.